

nered with St Xavier's College in Mumbai to host their college fest, Malhar. They become their "Official Internet Partner." They generated a buzz about their services by hosting games and events at the fest. More recently, Ogilvy, large PR company, handled a viral marketing campaign for Cadbury, which aimed at highlighting the idea that contamination in their chocolates was caused not during manufacture but in storage.

Business Directories

Registering your business under the myriad of B2B directories is one of the surest bets for getting new business. There are tons of Web sites, free and paid, that allow you to catalogue your business.

Advertising in prominent international B2B directories is important. Directories like Business.com allow you to buy a yearly listing for \$199 (Rs 8,100). Closer to home, some of the most prominent B2B directories are IndiaMART (www.IndiaMART.com), IndianYellowPages (www.IndianYellowPages.com), Yahoo! Directories (in.dir.yahoo.com), and ElIndiaBusiness (www.ElIndiaBusiness.com). Several testimonials from these sites suggest that a lot of business can be generated from them. All these directories are free to list in.

Niche B2B directories are another option. For example, there are sites like MagicBricks (www.magicbricks.com), on which you can put up information about all your properties on sale, lease, or rent, and RentACoder (www.rentacoder.com) from where one can choose to take up programming projects.

Other Methods

There are quite a few other ways to promote your brand on the Internet; quite a few of which don't require you to spend a rupee.

❑ **Content Participation:** These days, it is not only important to have a Web site, but also to participate in creating information. Sites like Wikipedia (<http://en.wikipedia.org>) and Yahoo! Answers (<http://in.answers.yahoo.com>) attract a lot of traffic and can be a great place to advertise. The idea is, you participate in building the content at these sites. Just having a small link to your site in the References section of Wikipedia—or among the answers at Yahoo! Answers—can drive traffic to your site. Another avenue is social news sites like Digg (www.digg.com) and Reddit (www.reddit.com) which display content on their front page based on the number of times that content has been voted for by its users.

It is important to con-



“Adding links to Google Talk and your e-mail signature is the cheapest way to market yourself online”

Rajesh Lalwani
CEO,
Blogworks.in

tribute meaningful content. Spam-posting your site's link all across such sites will cause your brand more harm than good. Post intelligently and mention your company only when required or under a relevant topic. Also take up membership at various Internet forums and add those links to your signature. Then, whenever you post in the forums, your signature with your company URL will appear below every post in that forum.

❑ **E-mail signatures:** Add your Web site URL to your e-mail signature.

❑ **Affiliate Marketing:** This involves your placing ads and links on a Web site in exchange for having their links and ads on yours. Then there are high-traffic sites that unknowingly facilitate affiliate marketing, such as eBay (www.ebay.in). These have a large number of users who advertise their Web sites within their store pages or at the end of every item up for sale.

❑ **Link Building:** This is a grey area in SEO; the ranking of your Web site in a search result depends on how many URLs on the Internet link back to your site. To increase the number of links that link back, you can have many links on a page that cross-link to various sections of your own site. When a search engine crawler indexes your page, it will see a large number of links, thereby increasing your site's ranking in a search result.

Endnote

For short-term advertising, it is best to go with PPC marketing coupled with a viral campaign in the form of discounts offered at social networking communities. You could also create a buzz around it by posting the information on Digg and Reddit. For recurring, long-term returns, however, it is best to SEO your site and participate in content-building activities on the Internet.

Naturally, not everything we've talked above will work for you.

We do hope some of it does, though. ❑
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